

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 29

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A street photographer steps off a tram into a peaceful protest he had not known about, and learns something about himself.

1

I had taken the late tram for no better reason than to use the last of the afternoon light, and I stepped down at a stop I rarely used because the camera at my hip wanted somewhere new. The pavement was warm under my shoes. A faint smell of cut grass drifted from the park railings. I had expected the usual mild Saturday — two boys on skateboards, perhaps, an old man feeding pigeons, the small ordinary scenes I had been taught to look for. I had not expected a crowd.

2

It was a strange sort of crowd. There were perhaps three hundred people, standing in the square with the patient stillness of a queue, holding hand-painted signs above their heads. No one was shouting. A young man near me was reading a paperback. A woman in a green scarf had brought a folding stool and was knitting. Whatever they had gathered for, they had gathered for it quietly, and the quietness, more than any noise, made me stop.

3

My hand moved to the camera before my mind did. That was, I should say, the usual order of things. I had learned over five years of street work to trust the hand, which often saw a picture before the eye had named it. I lifted the camera halfway and then, for the first time in a long while, hesitated. The faces around me were not faces I had stumbled upon by accident in the way one stumbles on a busker or a market stall. They had come here for a reason I did not know, and I had not earned the right to be among them by knowing it.

4

I lowered the camera and read one of the signs. It was a polite sentence, written in careful blue letters, about a hospital ward that was due to close. I read another, and another. By the fourth sign I understood,

with a hot rush of embarrassment, that I had been the only person in the square treating the gathering as a backdrop. Everyone else was, in some small way, taking part. I, with my expensive lens, was the tourist.

5

A girl of perhaps seventeen stepped out of the crowd and walked, calmly, towards me. She wore a school jumper and had her hair tied back, and she did not look angry — which somehow made me brace harder than if she had. “Excuse me,” she said. “Would you mind not photographing my face? My grandmother is in that ward, and I would rather she did not see this on the news.” She said it as one might ask a stranger to pass the salt: without heat, without performance, as a reasonable request between reasonable people.

6

I do not remember what I said in reply, only that it was nothing useful. I remember nodding, and I remember the small relief in her shoulders when she saw that I had heard her. She did not wait for an apology. She turned, walked back into the crowd, and within a moment was indistinguishable from the people on either side of her, which I suppose was the point. I stood there with the camera dangling from my wrist like an instrument I had forgotten how to play.

7

For a long minute I considered the square again, but with different eyes. The signs were still there, the knitting woman, the young man with his paperback. None of it had changed. What had changed was the small, hard certainty I usually carried — that any scene was, by right of my being there, mine to record. I had never thought of it as a certainty before. I had thought of it as a profession. The girl had not argued with me; she had simply, by speaking, shown me a door I had not known was closed.

8

I zipped the camera into its bag and walked the long way home along the canal. I have since gone back to the square, more than once, without the camera, and I have read the signs as they have been replaced or repainted. I still photograph strangers. I think I always will. But I ask now, more often than I used to, before I lift the lens; and when the answer is no, or when I cannot find a way to ask, I let the picture go. I do not think I have lost anything by it.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says he stepped off at the stop because “the camera at my hip wanted somewhere new.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase tells us about his approach to photography. [2]

2. Give **two** details from Paragraph 1 that suggest the narrator was expecting an ordinary, uneventful afternoon. [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes the crowd as having “the patient stillness of a queue.” Explain how this comparison helps the reader imagine the crowd. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator writes that “the hand... often saw a picture before the eye had named it.” What is **unusual** about this description, and what does it suggest about his way of working? [2]

From Paragraph 4

5. The narrator describes himself as “the tourist” in the square.

- (a) What does this word suggest about how he now sees his own behaviour? [1]
- (b) Why is the phrase “hot rush of embarrassment” effective at this moment? [1]

From Paragraph 5

6. The girl asks the narrator not to photograph her face. Explain how the language used in Paragraph 5 makes her request feel calm and reasonable rather than angry. Support your answer with **two** details from Paragraph 5. [3]

From Paragraph 6

7. The narrator describes the camera as “an instrument I had forgotten how to play.” Explain what this comparison suggests about how he is feeling at this moment. [2]

8. The narrator says the girl walked back into the crowd until she was “indistinguishable” from the others, and that this was “the point.” What does the word **point** suggest he has understood? [1]

From Paragraph 7

9. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 7 that shows the narrator’s view of his own profession has shifted. [1]

From Paragraph 8

10. The narrator says he “let[s] the picture go” when he cannot ask permission. What does this tell us about how his attitude has changed? [2]

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the disappearance of the family photo album in the age of the smartphone.

1

There is a particular kind of object that, until quite recently, lived on the lower shelf of nearly every family bookcase: the photo album. It was thick, slightly sticky from being pulled out and put back, and almost always slightly out of order. Looking through it on a wet Sunday afternoon was an unremarkable family ritual. Today, the album has all but vanished. The pictures still exist — more of them, by an enormous margin, than at any point in human history — but they are stacked in invisible piles on phones, untouched and largely unseen.

2

The numbers are, on the face of it, astonishing. A 2023 industry report estimated that around 1.8 trillion photographs were taken globally that year, the great majority on smartphones; this is more than were taken in the entire twentieth century put together. Yet a separate survey, by a British research firm, found that the average phone owner viewed only about 12 per cent of the photos in their own camera roll a second time. The remaining 88 per cent — the holidays, the birthdays, the small ordinary scenes — are taken and then, in effect, lost. Not deleted; simply buried.

3

The reason is partly mechanical. A printed album required choice. A roll of film carried twenty-four or thirty-six exposures, each one expensive enough to be considered before it was used. Once developed, the prints had to be looked at, sorted and slid into plastic sleeves, and this was its own slow pleasure. The smartphone removes all of those frictions: a single concert can produce six hundred photographs at no cost, and no moment of curation forces the photographer to decide which of them actually mattered. What is gained in volume is lost in attention.

4

There is also an emotional and historical cost that is harder to measure. Family albums were, at their best, small private histories — assembled, captioned and corrected by parents and grandparents, and passed down. Future generations could see who had been at the wedding, who had held the new baby, what a kitchen looked like in 1978. A camera roll, however vast, does not arrange itself into a story. The names of half-remembered cousins, written in pencil under a print, will not be written in metadata. When the phone is replaced or the cloud account closes, those images may quietly disappear without anyone noticing they were ever there.

5

Families have, of course, begun to adapt. Cloud services from major technology companies now offer effectively unlimited storage, and many parents share albums with grandparents through dedicated apps that send a discreet weekly digest of the latest pictures. Some couples agree on a quiet rule — perhaps a single “best photo” each day — and pin it to a shared album. Specialist services have appeared that will, for a fee, print a year of camera-roll photographs into a bound book, automatically selecting and de-duplicating. None of these is a perfect replacement, but each restores, in a modest way, the missing step of choice.

6

Small old practices are quietly returning, too. Sales of small home photo printers have grown for five consecutive years, particularly among parents of young children. Some schools now ask families to bring in a printed photograph for a wall display, partly so that the child can hold, post and hand over an actual object. Photography teachers report that more teenagers, not fewer, are asking for advice on physical

scrapbooking, partly as a quiet rebellion against the endless scroll. The album, it seems, is not dead. It has simply, like many old things, gone underground for a while.

7

Whether the family album survives in any meaningful form will depend, in the end, on something simple: whether people are willing to stop, every so often, and choose. To open the camera roll, to scroll past the duplicates and the accidental shots of the floor, to pick the few photographs that mean something, and to do something deliberate with them. A photograph that is not chosen is, in a quiet way, not really kept. The phone has given us, with great generosity, far more pictures than our grandparents had. What it has not given us is the ten minutes on a Sunday afternoon to look at them.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that photographs today “are stacked in invisible piles on phones, untouched and largely unseen.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about the way photographs are stored now. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** details that show how many more photographs are now being taken than in the past. [2]

14. The writer says the unseen photographs are “not deleted; simply buried.” What is the difference between these two ideas, and why does the writer draw the distinction? [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why does the writer say that “a printed album required choice”? Explain what this tells us about how film photography was different from smartphone photography. [2]

16. What is the effect of the writer’s phrase “What is gained in volume is lost in attention” at the end of Paragraph 3? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer describes family albums as “small private histories.” Why is this description effective? [2]

18. The writer says that a camera roll “does not arrange itself into a story.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. The writer claims that the new family practices “restor[e], in a modest way, the missing step of choice.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that support this claim. [2]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says that some teenagers are taking up scrapbooking as “a quiet rebellion against the endless scroll.” What is the writer’s **tone** in this phrase? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer says that “a photograph that is not chosen is, in a quiet way, not really kept.” Explain what is **effective** about this statement. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why family photo albums have largely disappeared**, and **what families are now doing to bring some of the album’s value back**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Family photo albums have faded because ...

— END OF PAPER —